Insight.

AI-Powered Prospective Student Experience

Turning website friction into guided conversations

Prepared for Murdoch University | March 2026

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Today's agenda

01 — The Challenge

What the research tells us about the prospective student journey

02 — The Solution

A working AI agent built for Murdoch, ready to demo

03 — From PoC to Production

Federating knowledge and building a platform

04 — The Strategic Case

Why this matters commercially and architecturally

05 — Why Now

The window for first-mover advantage

06 — The Roadmap

A phased engagement from pilot to scale

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The Challenge

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Your website is working against your enrolment funnel

MARKETING-OWNED
Study sub-site

MARKETING **Conversion-focused, brand-consistent**

Clear structure and on-brand messaging — but covers only part of what prospective students need to know.

SCHOOL / FACULTY-OWNED
Explore sub-site

EACH SCHOOL **Deep content, inconsistent experience**

Every faculty maintains it differently. No unified voice, no student-facing logic. Students don't know they've crossed into a different environment — they just feel the drop.

STUDENTS BEAR THE COST
The result

THE PROBLEM **Navigation that maps to org structure — not how students think**

Every unanswered question erodes confidence in Murdoch. That erosion is structural, not incidental.

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Three cohorts, one problem

COHORT 01

School Leavers

Comparing 3–5 institutions under real time pressure. Want instant answers. When the site doesn't respond immediately, they move on — and the next university that answers them wins.

ATAR queries | Scholarships | First year

COHORT 02

Mature-Age Students

Returning after a career or life break. Carry specific anxieties about belonging and whether prior experience counts. The site treats them the same as school leavers — no signal Murdoch understands their situation.

Belonging | Eligibility | RPL

COHORT 03

Growth Learners

International students and career changers navigating complex pathway information scattered across disconnected pages. High cognitive load, high-stakes decision.

Credit recognition | Pathways | Visas

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This cohort has already moved on from your website

2 in 3
prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google when researching universities

4% → 23%
high school seniors using AI to research universities (2023 → 2025) — six-fold growth in two years

IMPLICATION

Education is the **second-highest category** for traffic referred by AI tools. This cohort is not waiting for universities to catch up. **The question is whether Murdoch's answers are the ones being surfaced.**

Everspring, 2025 — 450,000+ student search sessions | Carnegie College Choice Trends Report, 2025

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The Solution

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What a guided conversation changes

Questions go unanswered
Information scattered across two sub-sites

Same response to everyone
No signal Murdoch understands their context

Students bounce to competitors
First to answer wins the consideration set

AI

Instant, accurate answers
Courses, fees, entry requirements & pathways

Cohort-aware conversations
School leaver vs mature-age vs international

Intent captured, conversion started
ACTION
Application links, tour bookings, advisor handoff

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What we've built

A working AI agent — built on Claude Sonnet, trained on Murdoch-specific content — ready to answer prospective student questions in real time.

REAL-TIME	Streams responses across courses, pathways, fees, entry requirements, and campus life
ADAPTIVE	Responds differently to school leavers vs mature-age students — cohort-aware
CONTEXTUAL	Maintains conversation context — students don't repeat themselves
ACTIONABLE	Surfaces next steps: application links, tour bookings, advisor handoff
ON-BRAND	Deployed within the Murdoch brand system — looks and sounds like Murdoch

I left school in Year 10 and never finished my ATAR. I've been working in retail management for the past 6 years running a team and handling operations for a mid sized store. I'm 25 now and thinking about going back to study something in business or management. Can I even get into Murdoch without an ATAR, and would my work experience count for anything?

MU

You don't need an ATAR

Since you're 25, you'd apply as a mature-age student. Murdoch's mature-age entry pathway is designed exactly for people like you — no ATAR required. Instead, they assess your life and work experience to determine if you're ready for university study.

Six years of retail management — running a team, handling operations, managing people and processes — is exactly the kind of experience that counts.

Would your experience count toward the degree itself?

Possibly, yes. Murdoch has a Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) process where your work experience can sometimes translate into credit within your degree — meaning you might not have to study things you already know in practice. It's assessed case-by-case, so there are no guarantees, but your background is genuinely relevant to a Business or Management degree.

What you'd likely be looking at

The **Bachelor of Business** (3 years, with a Management major available) would be a natural fit. It's available on campus and online, which gives you flexibility if you're still working while you study.

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Live demonstration

Walking through a live session — showing how the agent handles the queries your prospective students are actually asking.

School leaver · Mature-age · Course discovery · Entry requirements

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From PoC to production

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A knowledge platform, not a chatbot

The prototype draws from Murdoch's website content. A production platform would connect to authoritative source systems — live data, governed access, no manual updates required.

Source System	What It Enables
Course Management System	Live catalogue, units, prerequisites, fees
Admissions & Enrolment	Entry requirements, ATAR cutoffs, application status
Scholarships & Financial Aid	Eligibility criteria, deadlines, award amounts
RPL & Credit Transfer	Credit recognition pathways and assessment rules
International Admissions	Visa pathways, English requirements, CRICOS
Campus & Events	Open days, tours, orientation, accommodation

LAYER 1 **Data Sources**

Authoritative content and student data

Website | Course system | Admissions | Scholarships | CRM

LAYER 2 **Knowledge Platform**

Semantic search, grounding and governance

Ingest | Embed | Retrieve | Govern

LAYER 3 **Agent Interface**

Cohort-aware AI — action-oriented responses

Converse | Adapt | Escalate | Analyse

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Production-grade from day one

01 Conversation Design

Formalised cohort flows, escalation triggers, brand voice governance, and full accessibility compliance.

Cohort flows | Escalation | WCAG 2.1 AA

02 Integration Layer

CRM write-back for lead capture, application system connection, live advisor handoff with full context passed.

CRM | Applications | Bookings

03 Quality & Governance

Grounded responses with source citations, hallucination detection, Privacy Act compliance, sensitive topic escalation.

Citations | PII | Audit trail

04 Analytics Engine

Real-time dashboard, content gap detection, funnel attribution (chat → application → enrolment), A/B testing.

Dashboard | Gaps | Attribution

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04

The Strategic Case

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One capability, two strategic lenses

MARKETING

The Marketing & Conversion Case

Marketing investment drives traffic to a site that loses prospects before they convert. The AI agent is a conversion layer — it captures intent at peak engagement and turns it into action. Every question asked is also a signal about what students don't understand. That feedback loop is currently invisible.

- Conversion layer
- Intent at peak engagement
- Visible feedback loop
- First to answer wins

ARCHITECTURE

The Architecture & Platform Case

This is not a bolt-on chatbot. The architecture is built for institutional scale — model-agnostic, separated knowledge layer, integration-ready, and Murdoch-owned. No vendor lock-in. Content teams update without engineering involvement.

- Model-agnostic API layer
- Separated knowledge layer
- CRM & systems integration
- No vendor lock-in

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Why Now?

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The window is open — briefly

DEMAND

Students Already Expect It

2 in 3 prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google (Everspring, 2025). Six-fold growth in two years. This cohort is already asking AI about Murdoch.

TIMING

Technology Is Ready

Twelve months ago this was genuinely difficult. The models, infrastructure, and integration patterns have matured. The risk of early adoption has dropped substantially.

MARKET

Competitors Are Moving

Leading Australian universities are actively piloting AI student experience tools. The question is whether Murdoch leads that shift in WA or responds to it.

READINESS

Research Is Done

UX audit, user interviews, journey mapping — already complete. The path from insight to implementation is unusually short.

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The Roadmap

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Phased engagement roadmap

	W1–2	W3–4	W5–6	W7–8	W9–12	W13–16	W17–20	Scale
Knowledge	Website & course content				Admissions, scholarships & RPL			Live data feeds
Agent	Deploy to staging				Multi-cohort flows			Full journey coverage
Integration	Advisor handoff				CRM & lead capture			Bookings & applications
Operations	Analytics dashboard				Staff training			Continuous improvem...

PILOT LIVE

FULL COVERAGE

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From pilot to platform

Phase 1 — Weeks 1–8

Prove

School leaver cohort. Course discovery & entry requirements. Knowledge base built from Murdoch website content. Analytics dashboard baseline.

Phase 2 — Weeks 9–20

Federate

All cohorts. Connect admissions, scholarships & RPL data sources. CRM integration & lead capture. Multi-cohort conversation flows.

Phase 3 — Ongoing

Scale

Full prospective journey coverage. Authenticated access for returning applicants. Booking & application tracking integrations.

AGREED UPFRONT

Shared Success Criteria

- Engagement rate: sessions, session length, return rate
- Conversion indicators: application page visits post-chat
- Advisor deflection: % of queries resolved without escalation
- Content gap identification: questions the agent cannot answer
- Student satisfaction score

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A clear commitment to a defined scope

FROM US

What we bring

AI product expertise, a working prototype ready to demonstrate today, and an architecture Murdoch owns and controls. Not a proposal — a product.

- AI product expertise
- Institutional-scale track record
- Working prototype — today
- Evidence-led from day one
- Murdoch-owned architecture

FROM YOU

What we're asking for

A commitment to Phase 1 — eight weeks, defined scope, success criteria agreed upfront. Not a multi-year transformation. Eight weeks to prove the concept works with Murdoch's students, on Murdoch's website, with Murdoch's data.

- Eight weeks
- Course discovery scope
- Success criteria upfront
- Course & admissions data access

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Your students are arriving curious and leaving confused. We've built an AI agent that turns that friction into a conversation — and we're ready to prove it works.

The question isn't whether this becomes standard. It's whether Murdoch leads.

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Let's Talk

We're ready to walk through Phase 1 scoping, answer technical questions, and agree on next steps today.

Insight.

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Research evidence summary

APPENDIX A

Source	Key Finding
UX Audit	Navigation maps to internal org structure, not student mental models. Core information consistently difficult to locate.
UX Audit	Study sub-site (Marketing) and Explore sub-site (Schools) operate as separate environments — inconsistent layouts, terminology, depth. Students hit a jarring drop in coherence when crossing between them.
UX Audit	Mobile experience falls significantly below expectation for a primarily mobile-first cohort.
School Leaver Research	Students compare 3–5 institutions simultaneously. Whoever answers their question first, clearly, wins.
School Leaver Research	Interviewees expressed clear preference for immediate, conversational answers. One participant named AI as their preferred channel — consistent with broader industry research.
Everspring (2025)	2 in 3 prospective students prefer AI-powered search over Google. Education is 2nd highest category for AI-referred traffic. (450,000+ sessions analysed)
Carnegie (2025)	High school seniors using AI to research universities: 4% (2023) → 23% (2025). Six-fold growth in two years.
Mature-Age Research	Site does not signal that Murdoch understands returning students' specific circumstances or anxieties.
Growth Learner Research	Pathway information is fragmented across disconnected pages. High cognitive load, high-stakes decision.
Journey Map	Multiple drop-off points between awareness and enquiry — each a recoverable conversion currently being lost.

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Architecture overview

APPENDIX B

LAYER 1 Data Sources

- Course Management System
- Admissions / Student Management
- Scholarship Database
- RPL / Credit Transfer
- International Office Systems
- Events & Campus Services
- CRM (Salesforce / Dynamics)

Course Mgmt · Admissions · Scholarships · CRM

LAYER 2 Knowledge Platform

- Content ingestion & chunking
- Semantic embedding & retrieval
- Governance & confidence thresholds
- Audit trail & logging
- Content team updates *(no engineering required)*

Ingest · Embed · Retrieve · Govern

LAYER 3 Agent Interface

- Conversation engine
- Cohort detection & adaptation
- Response streaming
- Escalation logic
- Analytics & reporting

Integration: CRM write-back · Advisor handoff · Booking systems · Application tracking

Converse · Adapt · Escalate · Analyse

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